

to see and feel the initial benefits of the Web—but I guess at some point, they would want more. And hopefully, once they want more, they would naturally be attracted to Drupal. So I am not sure if I can call this competition for Drupal. In a way it is, but at the same time it will also introduce so many people to the Web, who can later resort to Drupal. So I think it will eventually be a benefit for Drupal. India already has 100 million Internet users. I see it as an opportunity for Drupal to flourish in India. And also, Drupal has never been good for minimal websites. People never use Drupal to build a five-page static website. So I believe it could be quite an opportunity for us.

Buytaert and Open Source...

Q What do you think of open source as an individual?

Every piece of my body strongly believes in open source. I think open source is a better development model. I think open source is an opportunity to disrupt a lot of software technologies, specifically those which I would describe as commodity technologies, for example, websites. There are millions of websites and I think open source can be a real game-changer. The other example is operating systems. Millions of people use operating systems. Because of its reach, I think open source can be very disruptive. That's been proven with Linux, obviously. As far as proprietary software is concerned, it will always exist, especially in certain niche areas. Like if it's a project amongst 100 people, it will not be feasible to apply the open source development model to such a project. Open source matters where there is scalability involved.

Q Yet the market share of open source is pretty small. What exactly hinders the growth of open source technologies?

I think it depends on how you measure things. Like in the mobile space, open source definitely has much more of a role in the form of Android. But it usually comes down to marketing, frankly. The typical open source community is good at engineering solutions but doesn't necessarily have the same marketing strength. Marketing is really required to help push the technology to the masses. With time and the advent of technology, I see the fear of security subsiding and this will give open source a much-desired boost. It will get accelerated in the next three years.

Q What are the real challenges in the implementation of open source technology and how can one overcome them?

Things like documentation come to my mind when I try to look for so-called drawbacks. I think open source projects don't always have good documentation. It depends on the stage of the projects also. Bigger projects have documentation but when it comes to small open source projects, the documentation is clearly an issue.

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Q What did you like most about the open source community in India and what do you find lacking here?

First, I have had some great experiences with the community in India. While in Delhi, we expected a hundred people and almost 250 showed up, which is awesome. It shows that there is real interest in Drupal and a passion amongst the people for open source. Yet another thing worth talking about is that, for the first time, 10 or more Drupal companies from Delhi came together. They got an opportunity to share their best practices. The positive thing is that they are starting to come together as a community. I have seen such a scenario before—that's why I know what the result of this will be. I am very excited to see the early momentum of the community.

A few criticisms...

Q Is Drupal difficult for users?

Drupal has a bit of a reputation of being hard to use, as compared to WordPress, Joomla and other enterprise solutions. That criticism is, in a way, correct—and we have worked on it too. Starting from Drupal 7, we have tried to simplify things. It is much easier to use now, but this does not mean we will stop in our efforts. We will continue to invest in usability. Drupal 8 will be an answer. We want to lower the barrier.

Q Does Drupal hate changes?

No, not at all. It's funny, because Drupal enjoys the reputation of being a CMS that changes the most. As compared to WordPress and Joomla, we change backward compatibility. We are always changing our APIs and our architecture. In Drupal 7, we made so many fundamental architectural changes. Unlike any other open source CMS, we embrace change.

Q Is Drupal disorganised?

Well, I think all open source projects are—and that's the beauty of open source! I think it's the nature of the beast, as all open source projects have thousands of volunteers all around the world. It's pretty hard to organise those numbers of people. I think this is a strength because there are people always working on Drupal and improving it. It's a huge advantage, but it's also an interesting challenge. But I don't say it's a bad challenge. It's a fun kind of a challenge. It looks like chaos, but the creativity that comes out of it is really amazing. The fact that it is disorganised makes it accessible. 